The next year, our collegue Panda was diagnosed with a tumour outside his food pipe, pressing against the heart. If left untreated, he wouldn't live too long, said doctors at Hospital Beaujon, an institution that Christiaan Barnard, the first surgeon to transplant a human heart, was associated with. Panda could not swallow anything, and the tumour was found to be life-threatening. A long journey could endanger his life, the doctors had said, and an immediate surgery, more complicated than an open-heart procedure, had to be done. The cost: 800,000 Francs (Rs 16 lakhs then).

I asked the Government of India for money, and my point of contact was a joint secretary, department of space. The bureaucrat said the scientist was not entitled to treatment abroad, and that none of the government rules provided for any allowance.

'Pack him to India,' he said.

'You mean pack his dead body?' I yelled back.

When he continued to be intransigent, I manipulated the French hospital to issue a formal letter saying the patient cannot be moved without the risk of fatality. The IAS officer was a veteran of such situations. Much later, on another occasion, he had the temerity to remind me that we had taken a loan (to furnish the St Marcel apartments) without the government's permission. I gave the official a taste of his own medicine. When we took the loan, ISRO was an autonomous body. It came under the newly-formed department of space only less than a year earlier. The department, hence, had no power to reclaim a loan disbursed by the government before it came into being.

Now, Panda's life was at stake.

I remembered now that his father-in-law was Banamali Babu, a powerful Congress MP from Orissa. During the team selection for Vernon, it was this bit of information that some people in ISRO had lapped up to campaign that I had included Panda in my team because of his political connections. Conspiracy theorists always find admissible evidences to build their case, but time eventually demolishes it.

Panda's wife said she would talk to her father Banamali Babu and pull strings in the Government of India to fund his surgery. Panda, an idealist,